
QMS-004 — Internal Audit Procedure

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1. PURPOSE AND SCOPE

This procedure establishes how Overleaf Publishers Ltd plans, conducts, reports, and follows up internal audits of the management system. Internal audits provide objective evidence of whether the management system: conforms to the organisation's own requirements and applicable standards; has been effectively implemented and maintained; and is achieving its objectives. Document reference: QMS-004.

Note: this procedure governs management system audits. It is separate from the Internal Verification procedure, which governs assessment quality assurance activities.

2. AUDIT PROGRAMME

The Director maintains an Annual Audit Programme, reviewed and updated at each management review. The programme specifies: the areas and processes to be audited; the scheduled audit dates; the method and scope of each audit; and the nominated auditor. The following areas are audited as a minimum each annual cycle:

- Quality Management System — all core QMS processes (enrolment, course delivery, assessment, content review, supplier management, document control).
- Health, Safety & Wellbeing — risk assessments, training records, incident/near-miss log, DSE assessments.
- Information Security — access controls, data handling, backup integrity, supplier security.
- Regulatory Compliance — IIRSM/RoSPA requirements, ICO/GDPR obligations, RIDDOR compliance.
- Environmental — compliance with Environmental & Sustainability Policy commitments.

3. AUDITOR INDEPENDENCE

Auditors must not audit their own work. As a sole-director organisation, where the Director is also the primary process owner, external audit input will be sought at least every 2 years for key processes to ensure objectivity. Appropriately qualified external auditors may be commissioned for critical areas including information security and regulatory compliance.

4. AUDIT PREPARATION

- Audit scope, objectives, and criteria confirmed and communicated in advance.
- Previous audit reports, outstanding corrective actions, and relevant process documentation reviewed.
- Audit checklist prepared, tailored to the scope.
- Auditee notified at least 5 working days in advance (except for unannounced audits where justified by risk).

5. AUDIT CONDUCT

- Audit conducted by document review, record sampling, and interview.
- Evidence collected objectively; findings recorded against specific requirements.
- Findings classified as: Conformance; Observation (potential for improvement); Minor Nonconformance; Major Nonconformance.
- Closing meeting held with auditee to present preliminary findings before finalisation.

6. AUDIT REPORTING

An Audit Report is issued within 5 working days of the closing meeting. It includes: audit scope, objectives, and criteria; auditor name and date; summary of evidence reviewed; findings and classification; recommended

corrective actions for any nonconformances; and overall audit conclusion.

7. FOLLOW-UP AND CORRECTIVE ACTION

All nonconformances identified in audit are raised as formal NCs in the Nonconformance Register and managed under the Nonconformance and Corrective Action Procedure. The auditor verifies completion of corrective actions at a follow-up review. Audit reports and corrective action evidence are filed in the Document Register and presented at the next management review.

8. RECORDS

Audit programme, individual audit reports, checklists, and corrective action records are retained for a minimum of 7 years. The audit programme is a standing agenda item at the management review.

For queries: info@chainsawcourses.com · Overleaf Publishers Ltd · Reg. No. 15735226 · VAT 479581629